

Ukraine Russia-Occupied Areas 2024 Human Rights Report

Executive Summary

In February 2014, Russia's forces occupied Ukraine's Crimean Peninsula, holding a sham referendum to claim annexation in violation of Ukraine's constitution and international law. The same year, Russia used proxies to set up ostensibly independent "republics" in Ukraine's Luhansk and Donetsk oblasts, which it assisted militarily.

In February 2022, shortly before the start of the Russia-Ukraine war, Russia unilaterally recognized the "independence" of these "republics." Russia again violated international law by conducting sham referenda in Luhansk, Donetsk, Zaporizhzhia, and Kherson oblasts in September 2022, and Russian President Putin signed accession paperwork that purported to recognize the four additional territories as part of Russia. Multiple UN General Assembly resolutions condemned Russia's actions and adopted a policy of nonrecognition of Russia's claims.

For detailed information on the laws and practices of the Russian Federation, see the *Country Reports on Human Rights* for Russia. Abuses by Russia's forces in Ukrainian territory liberated from Russian control are described in the main body of the Ukraine country report and are not

duplicated here.

There were no significant changes in the human rights situation in the Russian-occupied areas of Ukraine during the year.

Significant human rights issues in the occupied areas included credible reports of Russia's forces and proxies committing: arbitrary or unlawful killings; disappearances; torture and cruel, inhuman, or degrading treatment or punishment; unjust arrest and detention; serious abuses in a conflict, including attacks on civilian infrastructure and cities, resulting in widespread civilian death, enforced disappearances or abductions, forcible transfers of civilian populations, torture, physical abuses, and conflict-related sexual violence or punishment; serious restrictions on freedom of expression and media freedom, including violence or threats of violence against journalists, unjustified arrests or prosecutions of journalists, censorship, or serious restrictions on internet freedom; restrictions of religious freedom; trafficking in persons, including forced labor; and prohibiting independent trade unions or significant or systematic restrictions on workers' freedom of association.

Section 1. Life

a. Extrajudicial Killings

There were numerous reports of Russia's forces or their proxies committing

arbitrary or unlawful killings in occupied areas during the year.

In its December report, the UN Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR) cited 170 verified summary executions of civilians by Russia's forces between February 2022 and August 2024, as well as the deaths of 27 detained civilians from the effects of torture, absence of medical assistance, or inhuman conditions.

Impunity for Russia's forces' past killings in Crimea remained a serious problem. The Russian government tasked the Russian Investigative Committee with investigating whether security force killings in occupied Crimea were justifiable and whether to pursue prosecutions. International organizations and civil society reported occupation authorities failed to take adequate steps to prosecute or punish officials who committed abuses. Human rights observers reported families frequently did not challenge findings in such cases due to fear of retaliation from the Russian government. Ukraine's Office of the Prosecutor of the Autonomous Republic of Crimea also investigated security force killings from its headquarters in Kyiv, but de facto restrictions on access to occupied Crimea limited its effectiveness. The OHCHR reported during the year that 68 verified executions of Ukrainian servicepersons *hors de combat* (a term used in international humanitarian law that describes a soldier who cannot fight due to being sick, wounded, captured, or incapacitated) since February 2022. The OHCHR also stated photographs and a video circulated on social

media allegedly displaying execution and desecration of the corpses of Ukrainian servicemembers appeared authentic.

In October, the Office of Ukraine's Prosecutor General reported Russia's forces committed executions of more than 100 Ukrainian prisoners of war (POWs) since 2022. During the year, the office opened an investigation into a video circulating on social media that allegedly showed Russia's forces executing 16 Ukrainian POWs who had surrendered near Pokrovsk in Donetsk Oblast.

b. Coercion in Population Control

There were no reports of coerced abortion or involuntary sterilization on the part of occupation authorities.

c. War Crimes, Crimes against Humanity, and Evidence of Acts that May Constitute Genocide, or Conflict-related Abuses

In 2023, the Secretary of State determined that Russian forces had committed war crimes and crimes against humanity in Ukraine as part of the Russia-Ukraine war, which continued during the year. Russia also armed, trained, and led proxy forces composed of mobilized inhabitants of territories under its occupation (including parts of Donetsk, Kherson, Luhansk, and Zaporizhzhia oblasts and Crimea). Russia and Russia-led forces

throughout the conflict denied access to international monitors, who did not have the access necessary to systematically record violations or abuses committed by Russia and Russia-led forces.

Since 2022, a UN biannual report on the conflict detailed a wide range of war crimes perpetrated by Russia's forces, specifically those involving torture and extrajudicial killings of POWs and civilian detainees, sexual violence, unlawful transfer and deportation of Ukrainian children, indiscriminate attacks and attacks on civilian objects, and the use of weapons with high explosive force in civilian areas. The United Nations also found that the arrest, detention, and abuse of detainees might have constituted crimes against humanity. Russia's forces continued to use land mines without fencing, signs, or other measures to mitigate civilian casualties in areas under their control. Russia's forces reportedly mined roads, streets, fields, urban buildings such as hospitals and civic centers, and household objects, including toys and other items children would handle. According to survivors in liberated areas and Ukrainian authorities, retreating forces left behind mined areas with no regard for civilian life. Ukrainian authorities maintained that, in some cases, mined territory complicated the discovery of evidence of war crimes committed by Russia's forces, including mass burials.

Russia's forces and proxies carried out widespread detention of civilians, especially public officials, local authorities, human rights defenders,

journalists, and individuals suspected of supporting the Ukrainian government in areas controlled by Russia. The majority of victims were active or former local public officials, human rights defenders, civil society activists, journalists, and media workers. As of July, the Tribunal for Putin initiative, formed by a group of Ukrainian nongovernmental organizations (NGOs), identified 5,340 victims of enforced disappearances in the occupied territories. The government of Ukraine and civil society groups estimated as many as 20,000 Ukrainian civilians were detained in occupied areas of Ukraine or transferred to penal colonies in the Russian Federation.

NGOs reported that on June 25, Russian authorities abducted Iryna Gedzik from her apartment in Kakhovka, Kherson Oblast, after having broken into her apartment previously and confiscating electronic devices and documents. As of July, her whereabouts remained unknown, and proxy authorities had not provided a reason for her detainment or levied any formal charges.

Russia's forces widely perpetrated rape and torture, particularly against POWs and detained civilians, as reported and documented by the OHCHR and other human rights organizations.

On October 8, UN High Commissioner for Human Rights Volker Türk reported "patterns of widespread and systematic torture and ill-treatment" by Russian authorities of Ukrainian POWs, adding that evidence indicated "significant coordination" and awareness of the torture among Russian

authorities. The International Committee of the Red Cross visited several thousand POWs in Ukraine and Russia, although its access to Ukrainian POWs in Russian custody was significantly limited, according to Ukrainian government officials and civil society. Russia severely limited observers' access to detention sites, making monitoring and tracking Ukrainian POWs and detained Ukrainian civilians extremely difficult.

Ukrainian human rights organizations and media reported that Russia's Kursk Remand Prison No. 1 (SIZ-1) and Donskoy Correctional Colony No. 1 in Tula Oblast were particularly notorious for systematic torture of Ukrainian POWs. According to media interviews and testimonies of former prisoners recorded by the NGO Media Initiative for Human Rights detainees were deprived of rights and routinely subjected to torture, beatings, malnourishment, and forms of humiliation.

According to a March UN report, Russia's occupation authorities employed torture in a widespread and systematic manner, including use of conflict-related sexual violence. The report also documented widespread use of torture with sexualized aspects and threats of rape against male POWs. As of September, the OHCHR documented 342 cases of sexual violence by Russian authorities, 279 of which occurred in detention. Documented cases included rape, gang rape, forced nudity and forced public stripping, sexual torture, and sexual abuse. The cases occurred in different regions of Ukraine and in a penitentiary facility in the Russian Federation.

Ukraine's Office of the Prosecutor General reported 317 crimes of conflict-related sexual violence. As of September, law enforcement agencies were investigating crimes involving 202 women and 115 men; 15 of the survivors were children. The actual number of survivors was likely much higher due to the stigma of reporting such abuses. The ages of the survivors ranged from four to 82. Family members, including children, were sometimes forced to witness the crimes. The OHCHR reported that "different types of sexual violence were used as a form of torture to seek to obtain information or a confession, to punish, or to intimidate men and women in detention settings." Most detainees the OHCHR interviewed "reported severe beatings, including with batons and plastic sticks, pistol shots with rubber bullets, electric shocks, deprivation of water and food, mock executions, and threats. They also described dire conditions of detention that amount to ill-treatment and may, in some cases, amount to torture." Reported forms of abuse included rape, threats of rape, threats of castration, intentional damage to genitalia, threats of sexual violence against family members, sexual harassment, forced nudity, coercion to watch sexual violence against family members, sex trafficking, and humiliation.

There were reports Russia's forces relocated hundreds of thousands of civilians from Russia-occupied areas to Russia, particularly in the early months of the Russia-Ukraine war. According to the OHCHR, civilians seeking to escape the conflict were compelled to evacuate in any direction possible, even if they did not want to enter Russia. Ukrainian children

trapped in war zones faced death, injuries, separation from their families, and deportation to Russia. According to the Children of War platform, from the start of the Russia-Ukraine war to October 14, at least 579 children were killed and 1,644 injured.

Numerous credible international organizations, NGOs, and Ukrainian government agencies reported on Russia's systematic forcible transfer and deportation of Ukraine's children. Their estimates on the number of children involved varied widely. The Ukrainian Ministry of Reintegration documented 19,546 Ukrainian children deported to Russia as of October. According to human rights organizations from the Ukraine 5 AM Coalition, Russian authorities transferred as many as 260,000 to 700,000 Ukrainian children to Russia; it was unclear how many of these children were relocated with their legal guardians as part of Russia's filtration efforts.

The Yale Humanitarian Research Lab's Conflict Observatory documented in a 2023 report that Russia's forces and their proxies forcibly transferred or deported more than 6,000 Ukrainian children, including children ranging in age from four months to 17 years, to Russia or within Russia-held territories, at times without, or with coerced, parental consent, where they were held in "summer camps." According to the Conflict Observatory, at least 78 percent of the camps identified were engaged in systematic re-education exposing children from Ukraine to Russian academic, cultural, patriotic, or military education. A report by the Conflict Observatory stated that

“multiple camps endorsed by the Russian Federation were advertised as ‘integration programs,’ with the apparent goal of integrating children from Ukraine into the Russian government’s vision of national culture, history, and society.” Some of the children with unclear guardianship, particularly those living in orphanages or state institutions, were later transferred to Russian foster families for adoption.

Russian authorities relocated some Ukrainian children, including those residing in Ukraine’s institutions prior to February 2022, for supposed medical care in occupied territories and the Russian Federation. According to the report, “The camps and other facilities holding children from Ukraine were part of a system centrally coordinated by officials of Russia’s federal government.”

In a December report, the Yale Conflict Observatory reported that it had identified 314 Ukrainian children, almost all from Luhansk and Donetsk oblasts, whom Russian authorities had placed in coerced adoption and fostering programs since February 2022, 148 of whom were listed in Russian child placement databases, and 166 of whom had been placed with Russian citizens. The report also noted that at least 67 of the children had been naturalized as Russian citizens and had been moved to at least 21 different regions across Russia.

Numerous independent media and civil society organizations reported Russian authorities continued this practice into 2024.

In a June report, Human Rights Watch documented numerous cases of coercion against parents and teachers, including instances of beatings and torture against teachers and school officials to work or otherwise cooperate with Russian authorities.

Russian authorities intensified “Russification” programs for Ukrainian children in summer camps held in the occupied territories and in Russia. In May, the NGO Institute for the Study of War reported that Luhansk People’s Republic head Leonid Pasechnik claimed that Russia would sponsor 40,000 children from occupied territories of Ukraine to attend “summer camps,” an effort the institute characterized as part of a larger effort to isolate Ukrainian children “from their families, language, culture, and history.”

Human Rights Watch and other NGOs continued to report that Ukrainian children as young as six in occupied territories received military training in schools, including the use of weapons.

In 2022, Russian President Putin signed a decree making it easier to adopt and obtain Russian citizenship for Ukrainian children without parental care, thus making it more difficult for surviving relatives to return these wrongfully adopted children to Ukraine. Russia also prepared a register of suitable Russian families for Ukrainian children and offered payment for each child who received citizenship, up to \$1,000 for those with disabilities.

Russia did not allow sufficient access to international observers or

organizations to locate or return children; when children were located, many relatives had to undertake costly and dangerous trips to Russia and endure harassment and interrogation by security forces to retrieve their children.

Attacks on humanitarian aid workers and facilities continued. The UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs reported that as of October, access to the territories occupied by the Russian Federation remained extremely limited for humanitarian actors.

Section 2. Liberty

a. Freedom of the Press

Russia's forces suppressed freedom of expression, including for members of the press, through harassment, intimidation, abductions, and physical assaults on journalists and media outlets. They also prevented the transmission of Ukrainian and independent television and radio programming in areas under their occupation.

See the *Country Reports on Human Rights* for Russia for a description of the relevant Russian laws and procedures the Russian government applied and enforced in occupied territories.

The OHCHR UN Human Rights Monitoring Mission in Ukraine noted occupation authorities placed “excessive limitations on the freedoms of

opinion and expression.” In 2022, Russia’s parliament passed a law imposing a prison term of up to 15 years for spreading intentionally “fake” news regarding Russia’s military. Occupation authorities also applied an administrative article outlawing “public actions aimed at discrediting the Russian army” to prosecute those expressing dissent with actions taken by Crimean occupation authorities.

In 2020, occupation authorities began enforcing a law that prohibited the unauthorized dissemination of information damaging to the Federal Security Service’s (FSB’s) reputation without the organization’s approval.

Enforcement of this law in Crimea further deprived residents of the ability to exercise freedom of expression, by preventing them from publicly criticizing and disseminating information concerning reportedly unlawful actions of FSB officers and alleged violations or abuses of human rights.

Individuals could not publicly criticize Russia’s occupation without fear of reprisal. Human rights groups reported the FSB engaged in widespread surveillance of social media, telephones, and electronic communication and routinely summoned individuals for “discussions” for speaking or posting opposition to the occupation. The recordings were often used against the individuals in closed trials.

Occupation authorities often deemed expressions of dissent “extremism” and prosecuted individuals for them.

Occupation authorities continued to ban the display of Ukrainian or Crimean Tatar symbols as “extremist.” The NGO Crimea SOS reported that from March 2022 through July, Russian occupation courts in Crimea issued 818 rulings against individuals for allegedly discrediting the Russian armed forces. For instance, authorities detained Serhii Akinzhela for 12 days for shouting “glory to Ukraine,” brothers Ali and Seit-Khalil Appazov for 15 days for posting pro-Ukrainian images in a social network, and Yevhen Lebidko for 15 days for listening to a Ukrainian song and shouting “glory to Ukraine” from his balcony.

As of November, Ukrainian authorities reported that Russian authorities of occupied Crimea registered 1,093 cases under the code of administrative offenses of the Russian Federation, which pertained to “discrediting the Russian armed forces.”

Occupation authorities deemed expressions of support for Ukrainian sovereignty over Crimea to be equivalent to undermining Russia’s territorial integrity. There were multiple reports that occupation authorities detained and prosecuted individuals seeking to film raids on homes or court proceedings.

Physical Attacks, Imprisonment, and Pressure

The Institute of Mass Information (IMI), a Ukrainian NGO, reported that Russia’s forces committed 801 crimes against journalists and media in

Ukraine from the beginning of the Russia-Ukraine war through December. As of December, the IMI reported that Russia's military killed 94 journalists in Ukraine, 12 of whom were killed while performing their professional duties. Another 41 journalists were injured.

In September, Ukrainian journalist Viktoriia Roshchyna died in Russian detention after disappearing in August 2023, during a trip to the occupied territories. Her whereabouts were unknown until April, when Russian authorities informed her family that she was detained in Russia.

There were numerous cases of Russia's security forces harassing activists and detaining journalists in connection with their civic or professional activities. The NGO Media Initiative for Human Rights reported that as of May, 31 media workers remained in Russian custody.

Censorship by Governments, Military, Intelligence, or Police Forces, Criminal Groups, or Armed Extremist or Rebel Groups

Following Russia's occupation of Crimea and other parts of Ukraine, print and broadcast journalists resorted to self-censorship. In partially occupied oblasts, Russian television and internet monopolized the communication space.

There were reports occupation authorities sought to restrict access to or remove internet content concerning Crimea deemed subversive. In December 2023, the IMI reported that Russian internet providers blocked

access to all Ukrainian radio stations. Occupation authorities banned most Ukrainian and Crimean Tatar-language broadcasts, replacing the content with programming from Russia.

According to the IMI, Russian occupation authorities shut down all pro-Ukrainian media in occupied territories and established their own newspapers and television channel.

In September, Russian authorities detained Suleyman Yusupov for protesting authorities' decision to block access to YouTube.

See the *Country Reports on Human Rights* for Russia for a description of the relevant Russian laws and procedures the Russian government applied and enforced in occupied territories.

The IMI reported the media landscape of Zaporizhzhia Oblast changed radically beginning with the start of the Russia-Ukraine war. Since Russia's forces controlled most of the oblast's key cities, many media outlets were forced to close. Instead, Russia's propaganda television channels broadcast in occupied areas.

b. Worker Rights

Freedom of Association and Collective Bargaining

Occupation authorities in Crimea applied the labor laws of the Russian Federation. It was expected that Russia's labor laws would be applied in

Donetsk, Kherson, Luhansk, and Zaporizhzhia oblasts after their purported annexation (see the *Country Reports on Human Rights* for Russia).

Occupation authorities imposed the labor laws and regulations of the Russian Federation on Crimean workers, limited worker rights, and created barriers to the exercise of freedom of association, collective bargaining, and the ability to strike. Employers were often able to engage in antiunion discrimination and violate collective bargaining rights. Occupation authorities threatened to nationalize property owned by Ukrainian labor unions in Crimea. Ukrainians who did not accept Russian passports faced job discrimination in all sectors of the economy. Only holders of Russian national identification cards were allowed to work in “government” and municipal positions. Labor activists believed unions were threatened in Crimea to accept “government” policy without question and faced considerable restrictions on advocating for their members.

Forced or Compulsory Labor

The International Labor Organization received reports that those who remained working in the Zaporizhzhia nuclear power plant were forced to sign employment contracts with the Russian state atomic energy corporation, Rosatom, while still working under Ukrainian license, and to join unions created or controlled by the occupation forces, while the Ukrainian national operator, Energoatom, urged them not to do so.

According to the Nuclear Power and Industry Workers Union of Ukraine, some workers were forced at gunpoint to go to work at the Zaporizhzhia nuclear plant. Energoatom reported two workers were beaten to death and 10 workers abducted by the occupation forces were missing. In Dniprorudnet, Russia's forces enacted a system of forced labor for those without a permanent residence. On October 16, the Center of National Resistance reported that occupation authorities restored a Soviet-era practice involving requiring schoolchildren to work on farm fields.

Multiple sources reported occupation authorities forced civilians to work on the front lines for the Russian military.

According to Reporters Without Borders, Ukrainian officials located in the government-controlled area of Zaporizhzhya Oblast identified at least 17 Ukrainians who had been subjected to forced labor, including mine clearance.

See the Department of State's annual *Trafficking in Persons Report* at <https://www.state.gov/trafficking-in-persons-report/>.

Acceptable Work Conditions

Wage and Hour Laws

See the *Country Reports on Human Rights* for Russia for a description of the relevant Russian laws and procedures that the Russian government applied

and enforced in occupied territory. Due to a lack of available information, it was not possible to determine the degree to which the government effectively enforced these laws. Anecdotal evidence suggested enforcement was poor.

Occupational Safety and Health

See the *Country Reports on Human Rights* for Russia for a description of the relevant Russian laws and procedures the Russian government applied and enforced in occupied territory. Due to a lack of available information, it was not possible to determine the degree to which the government effectively enforced these laws.

Wage, Hour, and OSH Enforcement

See the *Country Reports on Human Rights* for Russia for a description of the relevant Russian laws and procedures that the Russian government applied and enforced in occupied territory.

c. Disappearance and Abduction

Disappearance

There were reports of enforced disappearances by or on behalf of Russia and Russia-led occupation authorities. Occupation authorities denied international monitors, including the OHCHR and the Organization for Security and Cooperation in Europe (OSCE), access to the occupied areas,

which made it impossible for monitors to investigate enforced disappearances. Human rights groups reported that de facto police often refused to register reports of enforced disappearances and intimidated and threatened with detention those who tried to report them. The Ukrainian government and human rights groups alleged Russia's security forces kidnapped individuals for opposing Russia's occupation as a measure to instill fear in the population and prevent dissent.

The OHCHR reported occupation authorities had not prosecuted anyone in relation to the enforced disappearances from Crimea since 2014. NGOs and media outlets widely reported occupation authorities were responsible for the disappearances. On June 25, the European Court of Human Rights ruled that Russia's occupation authorities committed systemic human rights violations in Crimea since 2014, including enforced disappearances, illegal detentions, and inhuman treatment of prisoners, and largely failed to investigate allegations.

The OHCHR documented more than 1,000 individual cases of unjust detention perpetrated by Russia's forces from February 2022 to June. The OSCE's Moscow Mechanism report, published in April, concluded that "the practice of arbitrary deprivation of liberty of Ukrainian civilians occurred on a massive scale and revealed signs of a systematic, consistent, deliberate pattern of conduct targeting specifically Ukrainian civilians." Although exact numbers remained unavailable, Ukrainian government and civil society

sources estimated Russia's forces unjustly detained tens of thousands of Ukrainian civilians.

Russia's military forces continued to detain individuals during filtration operations in occupied territory during the year, a process used to seek to identify possible affiliation with or support for the Ukrainian armed forces or authorities and to collect information regarding residents in occupied territory. Russia's military and its proxies often detained civilians due to suspicions regarding their political views, particularly related to pro-Ukrainian sentiments. This included local public officials, civil society activists, humanitarian volunteers, and informal leaders of communities, including teachers and priests. Russia's forces held civilian detainees for periods ranging from several days to weeks or months, often incommunicado, in unofficial places of detention. In July, Ukrainian NGOs identified 5,340 victims of enforced disappearances and submitted their findings to the United Nations.

Local media reported that on June 27, Russian forces kidnapped Zhanna Kiseliova, editor of the local *Kakhovskaya Zorya* newspaper and a member of the city council, from her apartment in Kakhovka, Kherson Oblast. As of July, her whereabouts remained unknown.

Prolonged Detention without Charges

Unjust detention of civilians was endemic in Russia-occupied areas of

Ukraine. According to the OHCHR, victims of unjust detentions by Russia and its proxies after the start of the Russia-Ukraine war were held incommunicado in unofficial places of detention, including warehouses and barns, without access to relatives and lawyers. Some of these individuals were later transferred to Russian territory. According to the OHCHR and the OSCE's Moscow Mechanism report, Russia's widespread use of civilian detentions amounted to enforced disappearances. Family members of detained civilians rarely received confirmation of relatives' whereabouts and had little recourse for contact or appeal of cases, according to the same sources.

While the exact scale of civilian detentions was unknown, as of March, Ukraine's Office of the Prosecutor General identified 164 unofficial places of detention and had recorded 5,600 cases of "unlawful confinement" in "makeshift" detention centers.

Civil society and international investigatory bodies described unjust detention as a systemic policy tool to instill fear, stifle opposition, and inflict punishment on those who opposed the occupation. According to the OHCHR UN Human Rights Monitoring Mission in Ukraine, Russia's forces focused on Crimean Tatars and raided homes of members of Jehovah's Witnesses.

On March 5, Russia's security forces conducted raids targeting Crimean Tatar and religious activists in Dzhankoi and Bakhchisarai districts in

occupied Crimea. Occupation authorities arrested activists on charges of belonging to Hizb ut-Tahrir, a Muslim religious-political group banned in Russia but legal in Ukraine. The Russian Federation continued to apply its antiterrorism and antiextremism legislation in occupied Ukraine, particularly against Crimean Tatars, human rights activists, journalists, and religious figures, to suppress political opposition.

Failure to submit to conscription into Russia's armed forces was also used as a basis for unjust detentions. Since 2015, Russia conducted annual spring and fall conscriptions in Crimea, and failure to comply was punishable by criminal penalty. As of December, the Ukrainian government estimated that Russian authorities had conscripted more than 50,000 residents of Crimea and opened 553 criminal proceedings for evasion of military service, 497 of which resulted in convictions. The Ukrainian government reported occupation authorities conscripted 5,500 residents during the year in Russia's 20th coercive conscription campaign in Crimea.

The OHCHR noted that compelling persons in occupied territory to serve in the armed forces was a breach of international humanitarian law.

According to the Office of the Ombudsperson, as of September 30, Russian authorities illegally imprisoned at least 218 persons in occupied Crimea on ethnic, religious, and political grounds, including 132 Crimean Tatars.

On March 5, in Bakhchisarai, Russian FSB officials detained journalists

Memet Liumanov and Aziz Azizov, along with eight other Crimean Tatar activists. In June, a Russian occupation court extended to November 4 the detention of Crimean Tatar activists Memet Liumanov, Rustem Osmanov, Aziz Azizov, and Mustafa Abduramanov, who had regularly attended Russian occupation court hearings of Crimean Tatar political prisoners.

NGOs reported that most civilian detainees were held by Russian authorities without formal charges or court orders, and that the respective regional department of the FSB would routinely continue their detention indefinitely via three-month extensions. Many civilians detained during the initial stages of the Russia-Ukraine war in 2022 remained in Russian prisons and detention centers under this procedure. NGOs reported these indefinite extensions were inconsistent with Russian law.

d. Violations in Religious Freedom

See the Department of State's annual *International Religious Freedom Report* at <https://www.state.gov/religiousfreedomreport/>.

e. Trafficking in Persons

See the Department of State's annual *Trafficking in Persons Report* at <https://www.state.gov/trafficking-in-persons-report/>.

Section 3. Security of the Person

a. Torture and Cruel, Inhuman, or Degrading Treatment or Punishment

Russia's forces reportedly employed systematic torture and abuse against thousands of captured Ukrainian military POWs and detained civilians. Nearly all released captives recounted torture and other physical abuse at the hands of Russia's forces, according to UN and NGO reports. Detainees were routinely held incommunicado in official places of detention, where they were tortured, including through the use of sexual violence, to extract forced confessions, disclose information, or compel cooperation. The OHCHR reported conditions of detention were so dire they could be considered forms of torture under international law. The OHCHR and the UN special rapporteur on torture and other cruel, inhuman, or degrading treatment or punishment reported that Russian authorities employed beatings – including with batons and hammers – electric shocks, suffocation, prolonged stress positions, excessive exercise, sleep deprivation, coerced confessions, mock executions and drownings, threats, and other forms of abuse and torture against POWs and civilian detainees. Most POWs interviewed by the OHCHR also reported suffering from sexual violence, including rape, attempted rape, and beatings or shocks to the genitals. The rapporteur also recorded detainees' testimony describing abusive detention

conditions, including overcrowding, starvation, low temperatures, and unhygienic conditions.

According to multiple sources, Russia's forces systematically tortured a subset of civilians and POWs prior to execution. In its September report, the OHCHR documented the death of 10 POWs and one medical personnel member in detention between 2023 and August 2024, due to torture, poor conditions, or inadequate medical attention.

The rapporteur also reported receiving credible allegations of deaths in custody. There were numerous reports documenting inhuman and degrading treatment of detainees by Russia's forces and their proxies in occupied territories. Human rights monitors reported occupation authorities also threatened individuals with violence or imprisonment if they did not testify in court against individuals whom authorities believed were opposed to the occupation. As of January, Ukrainian officials had identified 31 torture chambers established by Russian forces in occupied territories. According to the Ukrainian NGO ZMINA, Russia's forces employed torture against civilians as a tool to suppress resistance. Methods included electric shock treatment, beatings, psychological abuse, and forcing individuals to witness the torture of other detainees.

According to the Crimean Human Rights Group, the "use of torture by the FSB and the Russia-led forces against Ukrainian citizens became a systematic and unpunished phenomenon after Russia's occupation of Crimea." As of

June, the Crimean Human Rights Group verified at least 79 civilians were abducted from Kherson and Zaporizhzhia oblasts and transferred to Crimea.

Human rights monitors reported Russia's occupation authorities particularly subjected Crimean Tatars and ethnic Ukrainians to physical abuse. For example, on July 18 Russian FSB officials announced the detention of Crimean resident Seydali Smayilov for allegedly serving in an illegal armed unit – the Noman Chelebidzhykhan Crimean Tatar Battalion. Smayilov, who lived with a disability, was reportedly abducted a few days prior in the village of Chervone, Kherson Oblast, tortured with electric shocks and beatings, and forced to incriminate himself on video. Smayilov faced up to 15 years' imprisonment.

Internally displaced persons reported numerous instances of rape and sexual abuse by Russia's forces; many said they fled areas controlled by Russia's forces because they feared sexual abuse. Conflict-related sexual violence was rampant in Russia-occupied areas. As of October, the Prosecutor General's Office recorded 337 cases of sexual violence related to the Russia-Ukraine war, including 206 women, 115 men, and 16 children.

b. Protection of Children

Child Labor

See the *Country Reports on Human Rights* for Russia for a description of the

relevant Russian laws and procedures that the Russian government applied and enforced in occupied territory. Due to a lack of available information, it was not possible to determine the degree to which the government effectively enforced these laws in occupied territory.

Child Marriage

See the *Country Reports on Human Rights* for Russia for a description of the relevant Russian laws and procedures that the Russian government applied and enforced in occupied territory.

c. Protection to Refugees

Not applicable.

d. Acts of Antisemitism and Antisemitic Incitement

According to Jewish groups, the Jewish population in Crimea was approximately 10,000 to 15,000, with most living in Simferopol. According to the Jewish association, there were approximately 30,000 Jewish persons living in the Donbas. There were no reports of antisemitic incidents; however, Russia's occupation authorities' restrictions on human rights groups limited their ability to properly monitor antisemitic acts.

e. Instances of Transnational Repression

See the *Country Reports on Human Rights* for Russia for a description of the

relevant Russian actions.